

Romans

Freedom from Old Law

Chapter 7

<https://tinyurl.com/RomeGospel>

<https://tinyurl.com/TeachTheWord>

Faith, Hope, and Love

The Outline - Review

FAITH, chapters 1-8

- 1-3 Sin (GOD's great solution – the **Father** provides)
- 4-5 Salvation (GOD's great gift – the **Son** provides)
- 6-8 Sanctification (GOD's great work – the **Spirit** provides)

HOPE, chapters 9-11

- 9 Israel – Past
- 10 Israel – Present
- 11 Israel - Future

LOVE, chapters 12-16

- Practical Christian Living
- The **Just** shall **live** by **Faith**...

The Law in Context

A reflection of human behavior (sin nature of man)

*“For **whatever things were written before were written for our learning**, that we through the patience and comfort of the Scriptures might have hope.” Romans 15:4*

*“**The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked; who can know it?**” Jeremiah 17:9*

*“Therefore by the deeds of the law no flesh will be justified in His sight, for **by the law is the knowledge of sin.**” Romans 3:20*

*“Therefore we conclude that a man is **justified by faith apart of the deeds of the law.**” Romans 3:28*

*“Moreover the **law entered that the offense might abound. But where sin abounded, grace abounded much more.**” Romans 3:28*

*“For if the **ministry of condemnation** had glory, the ministry of righteousness exceeds much more in glory.” 2 Cor. 3:9*

The Law in Context

A reflection of the will and purpose of God

Psalm 119 – The Word of God revealed under the Mosaic Law.

Matthew 5-7 – The Living Word of God revealed in Jesus the Christ.

The Burden of the Law (refer to Exodus 20)

- Acts 7:53; Stephen before the Sanhedrin
- Acts 15:10; Peter refers to it as a yoke that none can bear

Romans 7:1-4

- In the illustration of the husband and wife, what is Paul's single point?
- How does this illustration reflect upon versus 6:2-6?
- What are the demands of law?
- Did moral law exist before the Mosaic covenant?
- Does a person have to die to some law before they can come under the Law of Christ?
- After the cross, what law did Jews die to?
- What law did gentiles die to?

Psalm 119 and Matthew 5–7 affirm the goodness and righteousness reflected in God's commands.

1. In the illustration of the husband and wife, what is Paul's single point? (Romans 7:1-4)

Paul's point is simple:

Death ends the legal authority of a covenant relationship.

A wife is bound to her husband while he lives. If he dies, she is released from that legal bond and is free to belong to another.

Paul applies this principle spiritually:

"Therefore, my brothers and sisters, you also died to the law through the body of Christ, so that you could belong to another, namely to Him who was raised from the dead..." (Romans 7:4, NET)

The focus is not marriage itself. The focus is that **death releases a person from the jurisdiction of a law covenant.**

2. How does this illustration reflect upon Romans 6:2-6?

Romans 6 teaches that believers have been united with Christ in His death.

We died with Christ.

We were buried with Christ.

We were raised with Christ.

Romans 7 builds on that truth.

Because we died with Christ, our former relationship to law as a covenant of condemnation has ended.

The death of Romans 6 becomes the basis for the release of Romans 7.

3. What are the demands of law?

Law demands:

Perfect obedience.

Continuous obedience.

Personal obedience.

James writes:

“For the one who obeys the whole law but fails in one point has become guilty of all of it.” (James 2:10)

Law does not offer grace.

Law identifies sin, exposes sin, and condemns sin.

Romans 3:20 says:

“For through the law comes the knowledge of sin.”

The Law is a mirror, not a savior.

4. Did moral law exist before the Mosaic Covenant?

Yes. Sin existed before Sinai.

Examples include:

Cain’s murder (Genesis 4)

The violence before the Flood (Genesis 6)

Sodom’s wickedness (Genesis 19)

Joseph calling adultery “sin against God” (Genesis 39:9)

Paul addresses this in Romans 5:13-14.

People sinned before Moses because God's moral standards existed before the Mosaic Law.

The Mosaic Covenant did not create morality.

It codified and revealed God's righteous standards in a covenant form for Israel.

5. Does a person have to die to some law before they can come under the Law of Christ?

Yes.

Paul teaches that believers die to their former covenantal relationship before entering a new relationship with Christ.

No one can be simultaneously under the old covenant and the new covenant as governing systems.

The believer dies with Christ and is united to Christ.

This allows him to serve:

“in the newness of the Spirit and not in the oldness of the letter” (Romans 7:6).

6. After the cross, what law did Jews die to?

Jewish believers died to the **Mosaic Law Covenant**.

This includes:

The Ten Commandments as covenant stipulations.

Ceremonial regulations.

Civil regulations governing Israel.

Paul specifically says:

“you also died to the law through the body of Christ” (Romans 7:4).

Since Romans is written largely to Jews familiar with Moses, “the law” here primarily refers to the Mosaic covenant.

Acts 15 and Galatians show the apostles refusing to place Gentiles under

that covenant.

7. What law did Gentiles die to?

Gentiles were never under the Mosaic Covenant.

However, they were under:

- The law written on the heart (Romans 2:14-15).

- The universal moral accountability of God's righteousness.

- The condemnation that comes from sin.

In a broader sense, they died to their former standing under condemnation and became united to Christ.

Both Jew and Gentile arrive at the same place:

- Not justified by law (Romans 3:20).

- Justified by faith (Romans 3:28).

- United in Christ.

- Living under the Law of Christ (Galatians 6:2; 1 Corinthians 9:21).

Pulling the Passages Together

Notice the flow of Paul's argument

1. **The heart is sinful** (Jeremiah 17:9).
2. **The Law reveals sin** (Romans 3:20).
3. **The Law cannot justify** (Romans 3:20).
4. **Justification comes through faith** (Romans 3:28).
5. **Grace exceeds the condemnation revealed by Law** (Romans 5:20).
6. **Believers die with Christ** (Romans 6).
7. **Death releases them from the jurisdiction of the Law Covenant** (Romans 7:1-4).
8. **They now belong to Christ and serve in the Spirit** (Romans 7:6).
9. **Sin no longer reigns because they are under grace, not under law** (Romans 6:14).

That is why Paul can say both:

- *“The law is holy, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good.”* (Romans 7:12)

and

- *“You are not under law but under grace.”* (Romans 6:14)

This does not mean God's moral character changes. Psalm 119 and Matthew 5–7 affirm the goodness and righteousness reflected in God's commands. What changes is the believer's relationship to those commands. We are no longer seeking righteousness through the Law. We have received righteousness through Christ and now obey from a transformed heart through the Spirit.

The Dual Nature of Man

The “Flesh” versus the “Spirit”

- The Law isn’t evil; Paul knows that for he serves it with his mind; he serves it as his standard of righteousness.
- The problem is, in his flesh, he doesn’t live-up to the law and thus is the servant of sin. His virtues and good desires don’t count. His sins are imputed to him both judicially and practically.
- Standing in his human nature (in the flesh), he is unable to live-up to what his mind freely recognizes and wants.

“Wretched man that I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death? Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord! So then, I myself serve the law of God with my mind, but with my flesh I serve the law of sin.”

“The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law.” 1 Cor. 15:56

Purpose of the Law

1. To expose our sin nature. Romans 7:7
2. To incite our sin nature to sin more. Romans 7:8-23
3. To drive us to despair of self-effort. Romans 7:24-25
4. To drive us to dependence upon the Holy Spirit alone. Romans 8:1-4

Romans 7:13-24

- Is sin a condition? Or, is sin a deviation from the Holy will of God?
- What gives sin it's power or ability to inflict death? (1 Cor. 15:56)
- Is the law spiritual?
- What are the different laws in his members?
- When he says: "It is no longer I who do it..." is he rejecting responsibility for his sins?
- Is the "wretched man" a Christian or not?
- Is the wretched man incapable of doing any good?
- Is the wretched man a captive to the law of sin and death?
- Does the wretched man live in a body of death?
- How does all of this fit in with Paul's argument that the Christian (logically) should serve righteousness?

Is sin a condition, or is sin a deviation from the holy will of God?

The Bible speaks of sin in both ways.
Sin is an act of transgressing God's will:
"Everyone who practices sin also practices lawlessness; indeed, sin is lawlessness." (1 John 3:4)
But Paul also speaks of Sin as a **power** or **principle** that operates within fallen humanity.
In Romans 7, sin is personified:
Sin deceives (7:11)
Sin kills (7:11)
Sin dwells in me (7:17, 20)
Sin produces coveting (7:8)
So sin is both:
Individual acts against God's will.
A corrupting power that resides in fallen humanity.
What gives sin its power to inflict death? (1 Corinthians 15:56)
Paul writes:
"The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law."
The Law does not create sin.
The Law exposes sin, defines sin, and brings accountability.
Without God's command:
Coveting remains hidden.
Rebellion remains concealed.
Guilt remains less obvious.
The Law shines light on sin.
Sin then exploits the commandment and produces condemnation.
That is why Paul says:
"Sin, seizing the opportunity through the commandment..." (Romans 7:11)
Is the Law spiritual?
Yes.
Paul explicitly says:
"For we know that the law is spiritual..." (Romans 7:14)
The problem is not the Law.
The Law comes from God.
The problem is fallen humanity.
The Law is holy.
Man is sinful.
The Law reveals the disease but cannot cure it.

What are the different laws in his members?
Paul uses "law" in several different senses.
1. The Law of God
God's revealed will.
"I delight in the law of God in my inner being." (7:22)
2. The Law of Sin
The principle of rebellion operating in fallen flesh.
"I see a different law in my members..." (7:23)
3. The Law of the Mind
The inward desire to agree with God's will.
"waging war against the law of my mind..." (7:23)
These are not separate legal codes.
They are competing governing principles.
When Paul says, "It is no longer I who do it," is he rejecting responsibility?
No.
Paul is not saying:
"The devil made me do it."
Nor is he saying:
"I am innocent."
Instead, he is distinguishing between:
His renewed desire to serve God.
The sinful impulses still operating in the flesh.
Notice that he repeatedly confesses the sin as his own experience.
He is explaining the source of the conflict, not denying accountability.
Is the "wretched man" a Christian?
Faithful Christians have disagreed for centuries.
Reasons some say yes
He delights in God's law (7:22).
He serves God's law with his mind (7:25).
The struggle resembles the believer's battle against temptation.

Reasons some say no

He is described as:

“sold into bondage to sin” (7:14)

“captive to the law of sin” (7:23)

Those descriptions seem difficult to reconcile with Romans 6, where believers have been freed from sin’s dominion.

I tend to see Romans 7:13-24 as describing a person under Law apart from the full victory described in Christ. Paul is demonstrating the inability of Law to produce righteousness. Romans 8 then provides the answer.

Is the wretched man incapable of doing any good?

Not entirely.

He desires good.

He recognizes good.

He approves of good.

But he lacks the power to consistently perform it.

The problem is not knowledge.

The problem is inability.

The Law can inform the conscience but cannot transform the heart.

Is the wretched man captive to the law of sin and death?

According to Romans 7:23, yes.

That is exactly why he cries out:

“Wretched man that I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death?”
(7:24)

The rescue has not yet been explained.

The answer arrives immediately in Christ.

Does the wretched man live in a body of death?

Yes.

The phrase points to mortal, fallen human existence.

The body itself is not evil.

But it is the arena in which sin operates and through which death reigns.

Romans 8 will later speak of the redemption of the body.

Paul’s Argument so Far...

Romans 7 is not Paul’s final conclusion

How does all this fit with Paul’s argument that Christians should serve righteousness?

- This is the key question.
- It is part of an argument.

Romans 6

- The believer has died with Christ.
- Therefore:
- Sin should not reign.
 - Christians should serve righteousness.

Romans 7

- Why can’t the Law accomplish that?
- Because the Law cannot overcome the power of sin.
- The Law exposes the **problem** but cannot solve it. (*“Who will rescue me!”*)

Romans 8

- The **solution**. (Romans 8:2 *“Set Free…”*; Romans 8:3 *“God Did It…”*)
- The Spirit provides what the Law never could:
- New life; New power; New desires; Victory over sin
- *“There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus…”*

Romans 8

The solution.

“For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death.” (Romans 8:2)

What the Law could not do:

“God did…” (Romans 8:3)

So Romans 7 is not Paul’s description of the normal Christian life as one of perpetual defeat. It is his explanation of why Law cannot produce righteousness. Romans 8 provides the answer: the believer serves righteousness not through the power of Law, but through union with Christ and the indwelling Holy Spirit.

The cry of Romans 7:24:

“Who will rescue me?”

finds its answer in Romans 8:1-2:

“There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death.” (NET)

The Law in Context

The Spiritual Life Revealed by Contrast to the Law

“For the law of the life-giving Spirit in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death.” **Romans 8:2**

Life by the Letter	Life by the Spirit
Depends on the flesh (Rom. 8:3)	Depends upon God's power (Luke 23:49; Acts 1:8)
Produces rebellion (Rom. 7:8)	Produces God's desires (Phil. 2:13)
Results in more sin (Rom. 5:20)	Results in righteousness (Rom. 8:4)
Brings wrath (Rom. 4:15)	Brings joy, peace, production (Gal. 5:22-23)
Not of faith (Gal. 3:12)	By obedience of faith (Rom. 1:5; Gal. 5:5; 2 Cor. 5:7)
Kills (2 Cor. 3:4-6; Gal. 3:21)	Gives life (Phil. 2:12-13)